

EL9: Documentation

Quarto

Reading

- [1, ch. 28-29] introduces Quarto with good examples

For reference

quarto.org

Levels of documentation

Documentation can exist at several levels in a project.

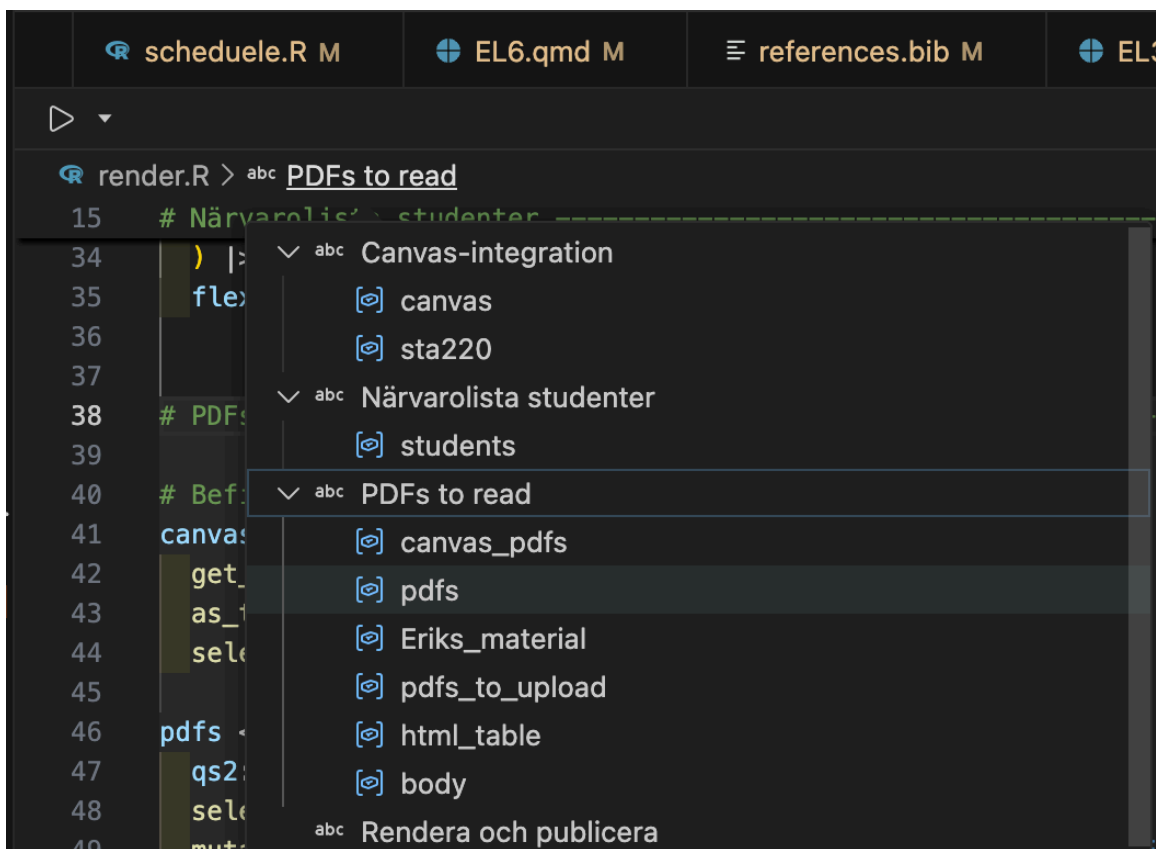
- **Code level**
 - scripts (comments, e.g. # clean data and merge cohorts)
 - functions ([Roxygen2](#) documentation)
 - notes and reminders (e.g. # TODO:)
- **Project level**
 - README.md
 - (GitHub repos may also have a wiki or a polished website)
- **Output level**
 - figures and tables
 - reports (PDF / HTML)
 - presentations (slides)

Code level

Documenting R scripts

- Use [Air](#) for better formatting of the R code itself (will format the code according to best practice for readability and collaboration)
- Section labels by Shift + Ctrl/Cmd + R in Positron (and RStudio)
- Easiest way to aid navigation to R scripts

```
# My section heading -----
```



Individual scripts

- As soon as you distribute an individual R script from a bigger project (by e-mail or as a printed copy) some context would get lost.
- The [commentr package](#) is designed to maintain such context
 - `remotes::install_bitbucket("cancercentrum/commentr")`

```
commentr::header_comment(
  "My nice script",
  "Bla bla bla ...",
  "Erik Bülow",
  "xxx@yyy.zzz",
  "John Doe"
)
```

The comment has been copied to clipboard and can be pasted into a script file!

```
#####
#                                                                 #
```

```
# Purpose:      My nice script                                     #
#                                                       #
# Author:       Erik Bülow                                       #
# Contact:      xxx@yyy.zzz                                       #
# Client:       John Doe                                         #
#                                                       #
# Code created: 2026-03-16                                       #
# Last updated: 2026-03-16                                       #
# Source:       /Users/xbuler/STA220/documentation               #
#                                                       #
# Comment:      Bla bla bla ...                                   #
#                                                       #
#####
```



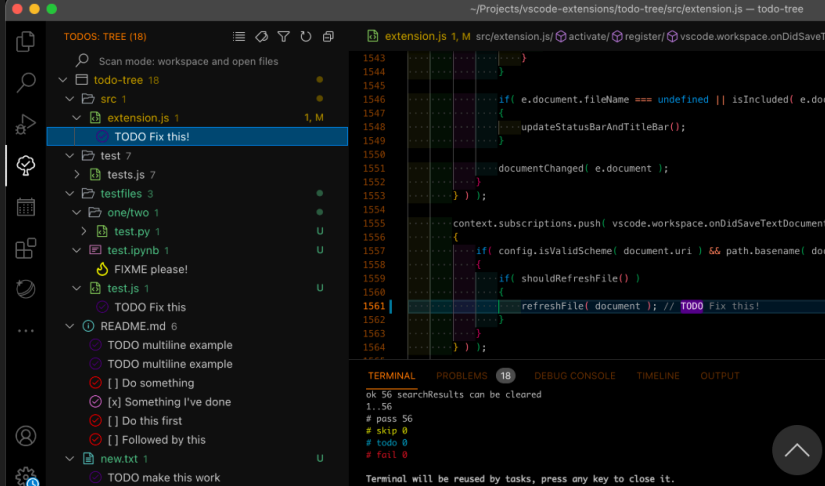
Todo Tree

Gruntfuggly | 301,391 | ★★★★★ (4)

Show TODO, FIXME, etc. comment tags in a tree view

Disable
Uninstall
✓ Auto Update

DETAILS | FEATURES | CHANGELOG



Installation

Identifier	gruntfuggly.tree
Version	0.0.215
Last Updated	1 year ago
Size	1.15MB
Cache	2.35KB

Marketplace

Published	5 years ago
Last Released	4 years ago

```
# TODO: Change this to something better:
1 + 2
```

Documenting R functions

What does this function do?

```
hello <- function(who = "world") {
  sprintf("Hello %s!", who)
}
```

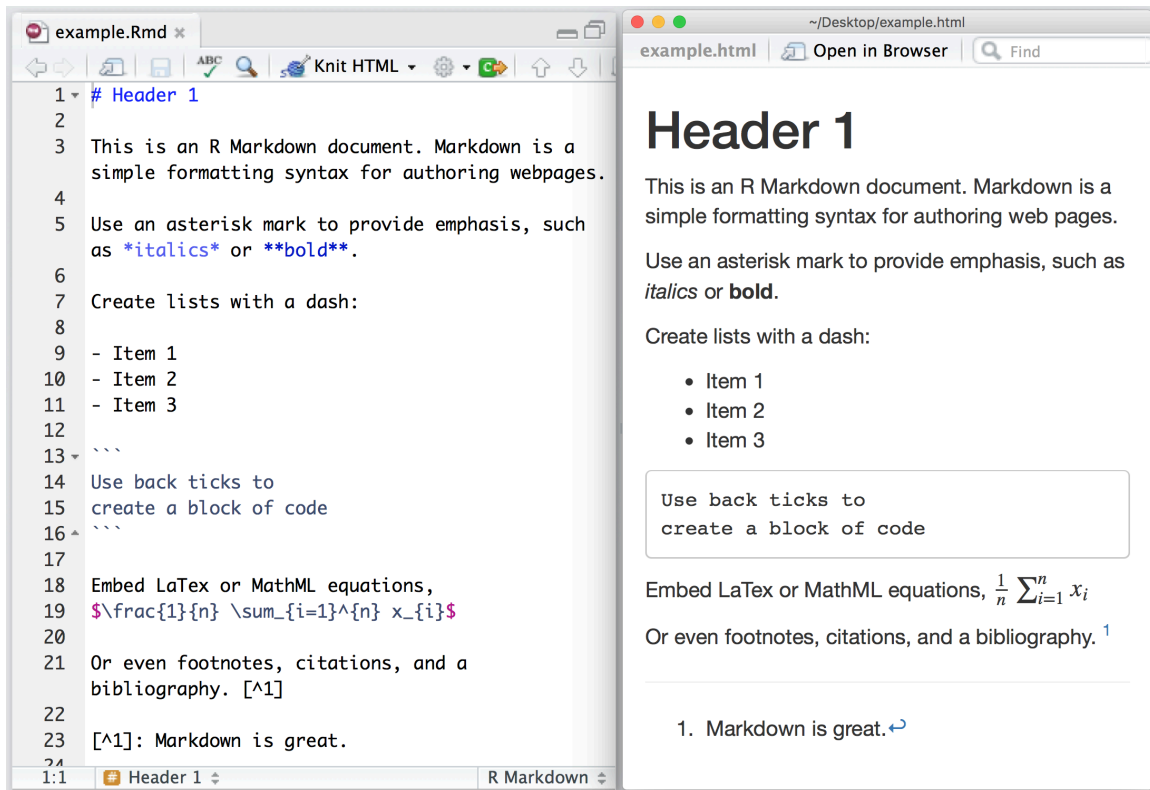
```
#' Say hello
#'
#' Create a simple greeting. If no name is provided, the function
#' returns a greeting to the world.
#'
#' @param who A character vector giving the name(s) of the person or
#' object to greet. If missing, the greeting defaults to `"world"`.
#'
#' @return A character vector of the same length as `who` containing
#' greeting messages.
#'
#' @examples
#' hello()
#' hello("you")
#' hello(c("Alice", "Bob"))
hello <- function(who = "world") {
  sprintf("Hello %s!", who)
}
```

- There is a standardized syntax to document R functions
- You should be able to click a small light bulb (💡) to insert a skeleton when writing your function
- The same syntax is used within modern R packages
 - but it is useful even within your own projects
- [roxygen2](#) is a package used for package documentation but it also has a great [manual for documenting functions in general](#)

Project level

Documenting a project

- You have a README.md file within your git repository
- It can contain plain text without any formatting
- It will be displayed up-front in GitHub
- You can also include formatting!
- It will be nicely rendered on GitHub or elsewhere



Basic formatting

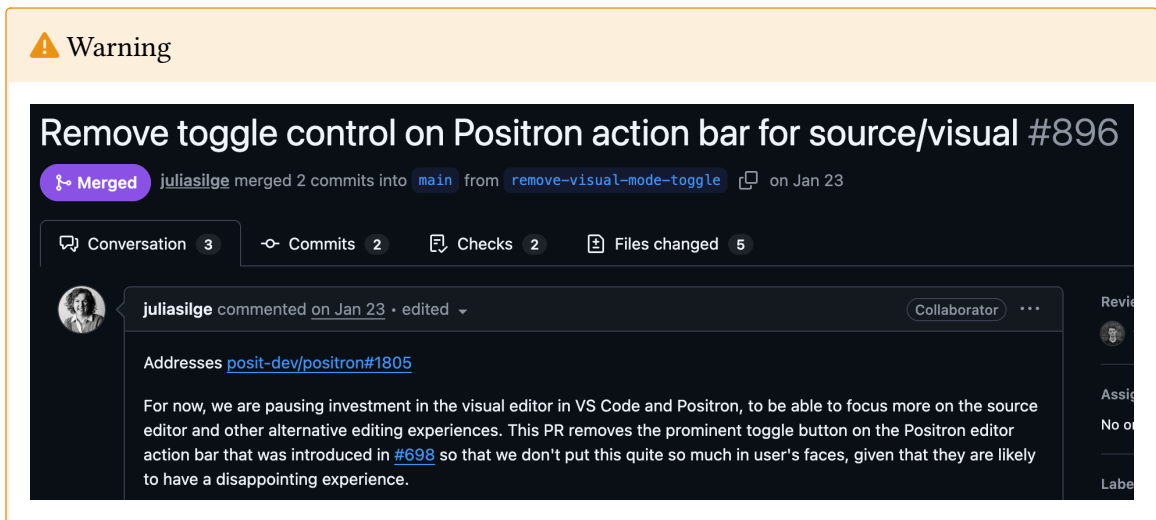
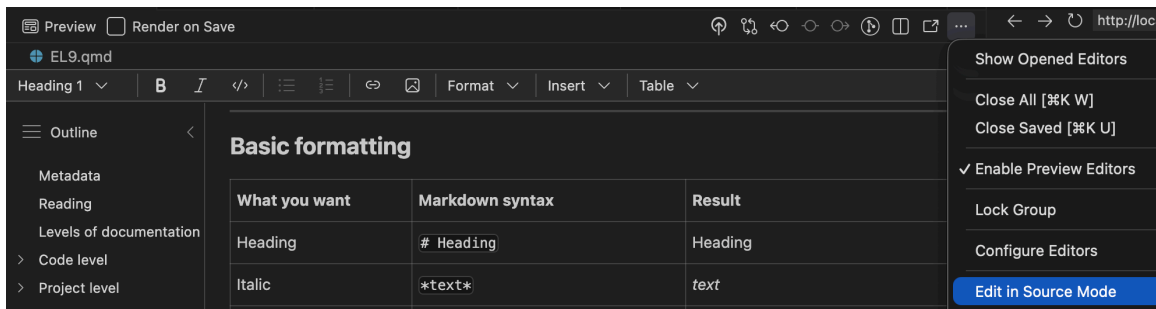
What you want	Markdown syntax	Result
Heading	# Heading	Heading
Italic	<i>*text*</i>	<i>text</i>
Bold	**text**	text
Inline code	`code`	code
Link	[text](https://example.com)	text
Bullet list	- item	• item
Numbered list	1. item	1. item

i Comment or heading

is used for comments in R files and within R blocks but for headings in .md and .qmd files!

Visual mode

Instead of editing the source code, you may also use the “visual editor” in Positron:



Use both?

Personally, I do most editing in source mode (better for the R chunks), but I find it much easier to include references/citations and to paste in external figures in using the visual mode.

Reproducible Workflows

Modern biostatistics projects rarely involve only statistics.

- data cleaning and preprocessing
- statistical modelling
- visualisation
- interpretation of results
- reporting and documentation

A good workflow should make it possible to **combine all of these steps in one place**.

Output level

What?

Quarto is a publishing system for scientific and technical documents.

It allows you to combine:

- text
- R code
- statistical results
- tables and figures

in a **single workflow**.

This makes it easier to create **reproducible statistical reports**.

Why?

In many projects people work with:

- R scripts for analysis 🤖
- Word documents for reporting 📄
- PowerPoint slides for presentations 🗣️

This separation often leads to:

- copy-paste errors 😞
- outdated figures 👎
- results that cannot easily be reproduced 🤯

Quarto helps avoid these problems!

Reproducible analysis

In a Quarto document you can:

1. write the explanation of your analysis
 2. include the R code used
 3. generate figures and tables automatically
 4. update everything by re-running the document
- If the data or model changes, the **entire report can be regenerated automatically**.
 - It is widely used in **data science, epidemiology and biostatistics**.
 - Integrated in Positron and developed by Posit PBC

Used in three ways

1. For **communicating to decision-makers**, who want to *focus on the conclusions, not the code behind the analysis*.
2. For **collaborating with colleagues** (including future you!), who are interested in both your *conclusions, and how you reached them (i.e. the code)*.
3. As an **environment** in which to do data science and statistics, as a modern-day lab notebook where you can capture not only what you did, but also what you were thinking.

A simple report

When you chose New > New File ... > Quarto document, the file will contain:

```

---
title: "Untitled"
format: html
---

```

- This is a YAML header (Yet Another Markup Language)
- Different output formats are available:
 - **html**: can also be published online ([Quartopub](#) or [GitHub pages](#))
 - **docx**: Word document for collaborating with non-statisticians etc
 - **typst**: PDF rendering (ever heard of $\LaTeX$? ... This is the modern alternative!)
 - **revealjs**: slide decks (you are looking at one!)
- Can render to multiple formats at once!

This is the yaml header for this presentation:

```

---
title: "EL9: Documentation"
subtitle: "Quarto"
reading: "[@wickham, ch. 28-29]"
format:
  revealjs:
    theme: blood
    transition: fade
    slide-number: true
    css: styles.css
    smaller: true
    scrollable: true
    incremental: false
  typst:
    include-before-body:
      - text: |
          // Gör alla länkar tydliga i PDF: blå + understrukna
          #show link: set text(fill: rgb("1a5fb4"))
          #show link: underline
    docx: default
  bibliography: references.bib
---

```

YAML structure

YAML uses **indentation to represent structure**.

Think of it like a tree.


```
format:
  html:
    code-fold: true
```

This corresponds to the structure:

```
format
└─ html
   └─ code-fold: true
```

If indentation is wrong?

```
format:
html:
  code-fold: true
```

Now Quarto interprets this as:

```
format
html
└─ code-fold: true
```

This is **not the intended structure**, and the document may fail to render.

💡 Rule of thumb

- use **two spaces per level**
- never use **tabs**
- when something fails, **check indentation first**

Three parts

Quarto documents have three parts:

1. An (optional) YAML header surrounded by ---s.
2. Chunks of R code surrounded by ```{r} and ```.

```
```{r}           ← chunk header
#| echo: false ← options controlling the output
summary(x) ← R code
```             ← end of chunk
```

Keybindings: Cmd + option + I (Mac) or Ctrl + Alt + I (Windows)

3. Text with markdown format

💡 Order

Part 1 (YAML header) always comes first but 2 (code block) and 3 (Markdown text) are usually intermingled throughout the rest of the document.

Inline code

Sometimes we want to insert **small pieces of R output directly in the text**.

This is called **inline code**.

Inline code will always just show the result of the call (not the code itself in the rendered document):

```
Todays date is `r Sys.Date()` and it is `r format(Sys.time(), format = "%H")`
```

Todys date is 2026-03-16 and it is 10 AM

To highlight with bold and italic:

```
Todays date is `r Sys.Date()` and it is `r format(Sys.time(), format = "%I %p")`
```

Todays date is **2026-03-16** and it is *10 AM*

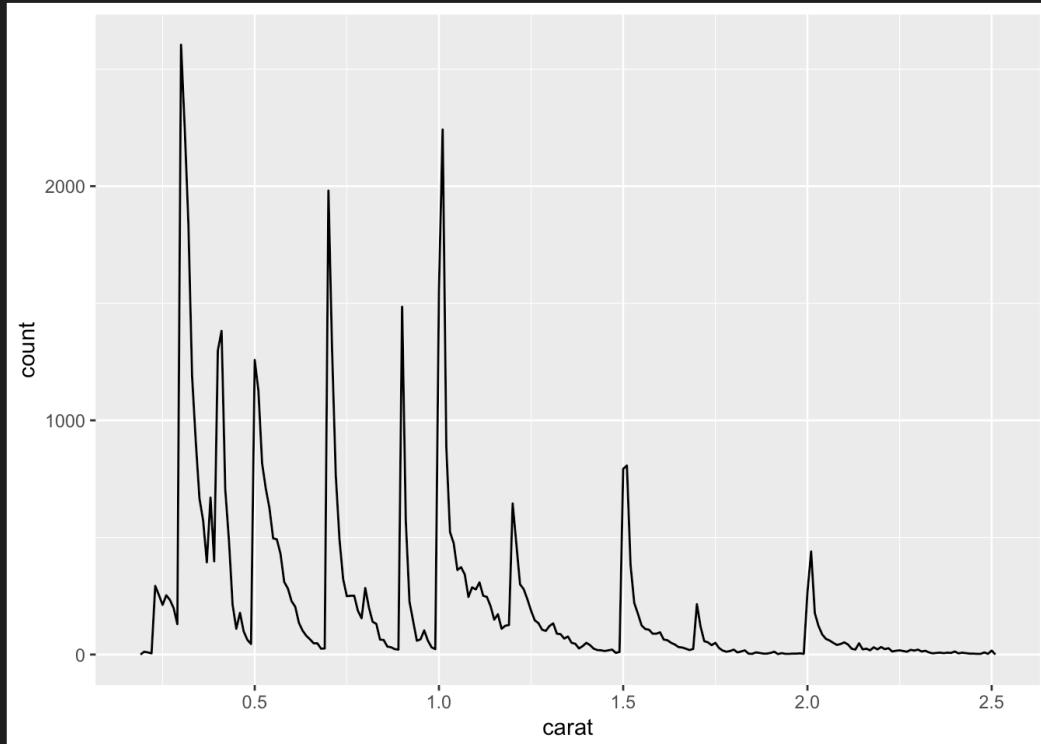
```
Preview ☐ Render on Save 🔍 📄 📄 ...

1 ---
2 title: "Diamond sizes"
3 date: 2022-09-12
4 format: html
5 ---
6
7 >Run Cell | Run Next Cell
8 ```{r}
9 #| label: setup
10 #| include: false
11
12 library(tidyverse)
13
14 smaller <- diamonds |>
15   filter(carat <= 2.5)
16   ```
17
18 We have data about `r nrow(diamonds)` diamonds.
19 Only `r nrow(diamonds) - nrow(smaller)` are larger than 2.5 carats.
20 The distribution of the remainder is shown below:
21
22 >Run Cell | Run Above
23 ```{r}
24 #| label: plot-smaller-diamonds
25 #| echo: false
26
27 smaller |>
28   ggplot(aes(x = carat)) +
29     geom_freqpoly(binwidth = 0.01)
30   ```
```

Diamond sizes

PUBLISHED
September 12, 2022

We have data about 53940 diamonds. Only 126 are larger than 2.5 carats. The distribution of the remainder is shown below:



To publish

Decision makers, stake holders, friends or the public might not care about R. Disable R code (echoing the code itself), warnings and messages:

```
---  
title: "Untitled"  
format: html  
execute:  
  echo: false  
  warning: false  
  message: false  
---
```

For collaborators

- Might still care less about verbose R messages and warnings (they trust that you have already considered those)
- May still need the underlying R code for deeper understanding
- Use code-fold

```
---  
title: "Untitled"  
format:  
  html:  
    code-fold: true  
execute:  
  warning: false  
  message: false  
---
```

Till manus

AUTHOR
Erik Bülow

PUBLISHED
November 21, 2025

Jag utgår från ett sammanslagna datasettet ([df](#)) med alla variabler. Utifrån det datasettet har Sofia markerat vilka variabler som är lämpliga att inkludera i en Table 1 (vilket var preliminärt så kanske behöver fastställas):

2025-11-06: Lägger till utfallsvariabler också som saknats.

► Code

name	class	unique	better_name	include_in_table1	outcome	KOMMENTAR
age	numeric	N = 38	NA	X	NA	NA
sex	factor	male, female	NA	X	NA	NA
group	factor	Individual, Traditional	NA	X	NA	NA

Table of contents

- [Outliers](#)
- Transfomerad data
- Tider
- Table 1
- Baseline
- 3 månader
- 12 månader
- Table 2
- Table 3
- Fig 1
- Fig 2
- Jämförelse mot powerberäkning

Till manus

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2025-11-06: Lägger till utfallsvariabler också som saknats.

▼ Code

```
vars <- readxl::read_excel(here("docs/250529_vars_SM.xlsx"))
vars2incl <- vars$name[!is.na(vars$include_in_table1)]
vars2incl <- vars$name[!is.na(vars$include_in_table1) | !is.na(vars$outcome)]
vars |>
  filter(!is.na(include_in_table1) | !is.na(outcome)) |>
  knitr::kable()
```

name	class	unique	better_name	include_in_table1	outcome	KOMMENTAR
age	numeric	N = 38	NA	X	NA	NA
sex	factor	male, female	NA	X	NA	NA

This can also be set individually for each code chunk:

```
```${r}
#| echo: false
#| warning: false
#| message: true
message("will be muted!")
warning("will be ignored")
plot(something_beautiful, realy = TRUE)
```
```

Figures

Figures are usually displayed without problem (and you can adjust their size, add captions etc):

```
```${r}
#| fig-cap: This is origo!
plot(0, 0)
```
```

```
plot(0, 0)
```

Table of contents

Outliers

Transfomerad data

Tider

Table 1

Baseline

3 månader

12 månader

Table 2

Table 3

Fig 1

Fig 2

Jämförelse mot
powerberäkning

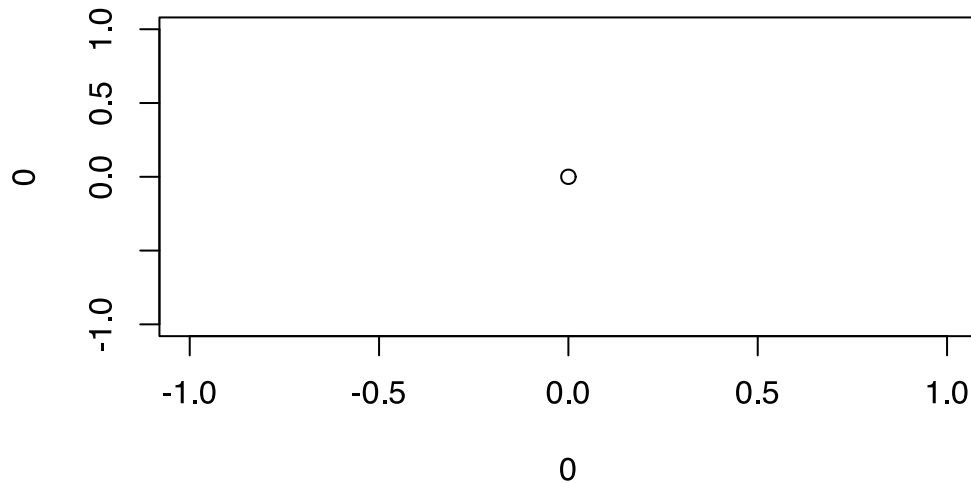


Figure 1: This is origo!

Tables

Just printing the R output might not look very nice:

```
head(iris)
```

| | Sepal.Length | Sepal.Width | Petal.Length | Petal.Width | Species |
|---|--------------|-------------|--------------|-------------|---------|
| 1 | 5.1 | 3.5 | 1.4 | 0.2 | setosa |
| 2 | 4.9 | 3.0 | 1.4 | 0.2 | setosa |
| 3 | 4.7 | 3.2 | 1.3 | 0.2 | setosa |
| 4 | 4.6 | 3.1 | 1.5 | 0.2 | setosa |
| 5 | 5.0 | 3.6 | 1.4 | 0.2 | setosa |
| 6 | 5.4 | 3.9 | 1.7 | 0.4 | setosa |

Better with kable

The easiest way to make tibbles/data.frames/data.tables look nicer is with `df-print`: `kable` in the yaml header.

```
---
title: "Untitled"
format: html
df-print: kable
---
```

Or manually for individual outputs:

```
```\r}\n#| tbl-cap: Some iris data\nknitr::kable(head(iris))\n```\n
```

```
knitr::kable(head(iris))
```

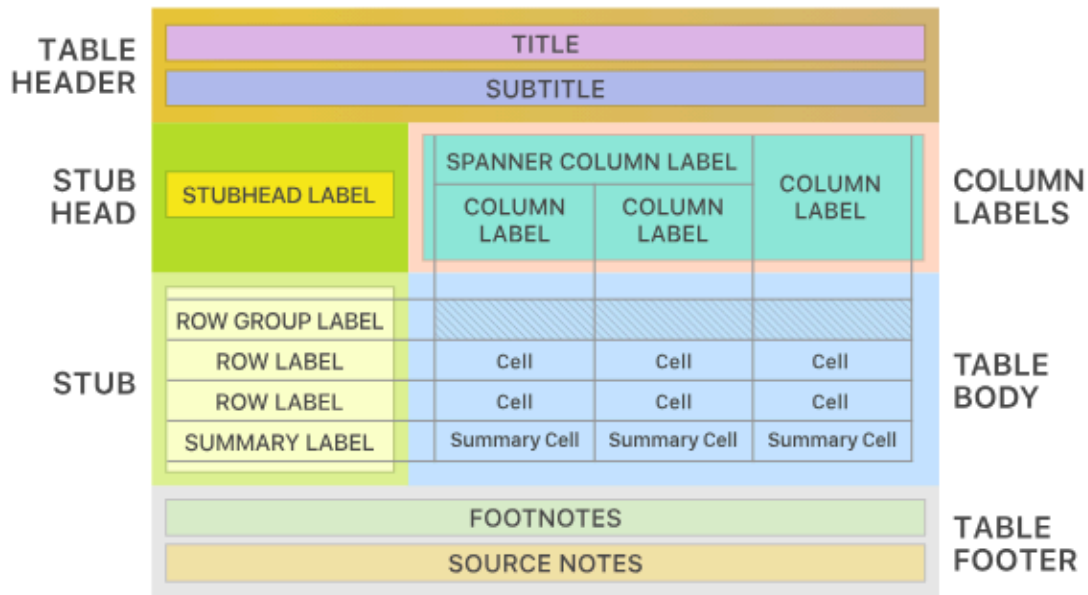
| Sepal.Length | Sepal.Width | Petal.Length | Petal.Width | Species |
|--------------|-------------|--------------|-------------|---------|
| 5.1          | 3.5         | 1.4          | 0.2         | setosa  |
| 4.9          | 3.0         | 1.4          | 0.2         | setosa  |
| 4.7          | 3.2         | 1.3          | 0.2         | setosa  |
| 4.6          | 3.1         | 1.5          | 0.2         | setosa  |
| 5.0          | 3.6         | 1.4          | 0.2         | setosa  |
| 5.4          | 3.9         | 1.7          | 0.4         | setosa  |

### Best with gt

- Very flexible
  - Publication ready
  - [Package from Posit](#)
  - [flextable](#) may be preferred instead if rendering Office documents (Word, PowerPoint)
-



## The Parts of a gt Table



## A Typical gt Workflow



### gtsummary

[gtsummary package](#) build on top of {gt} to easily summarise datasets, regression models etc

```
```{r}
gtsummary::tbl_summary(iris, Species)
```
```

```
gtsummary::tbl_summary(iris, Species)
```

| Characteristic | setosa<br>N = 50 <sup>1</sup> | versicolor<br>N = 50 <sup>1</sup> | virginica<br>N = 50 <sup>1</sup> |
|----------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Sepal.Length   | 5.00 (4.80, 5.20)             | 5.90 (5.60, 6.30)                 | 6.50 (6.20, 6.90)                |
| Sepal.Width    | 3.40 (3.20, 3.70)             | 2.80 (2.50, 3.00)                 | 3.00 (2.80, 3.20)                |
| Petal.Length   | 1.50 (1.40, 1.60)             | 4.35 (4.00, 4.60)                 | 5.55 (5.10, 5.90)                |
| Petal.Width    | 0.20 (0.20, 0.30)             | 1.30 (1.20, 1.50)                 | 2.00 (1.80, 2.30)                |

<sup>1</sup> Median (Q1, Q3)

## Presentations

- Quarto can export to PowerPoint
- And to the older Beamer format
- But I recommend [revealjs](#)
  - format: revealjs
  - can also be modified with speaker notes, laser pointer etc
- [Info and examples](#)

For example (as used for these slides):

```
format:
 revealjs:
 theme: blood
 transition: fade
 slide-number: true
 css: styles.css
 smaller: true
 scrollable: true
 incremental: false
```

## Integrate with {targets}

[tarchetypes::tar\\_quarto\(\)](#)

in `_targets.R`

```
library(targets)
library(tarchetypes) # Let you integrate a quarto report/presentation
list(
 tar_target(data, data.frame(x = seq_len(26), y = letters))
 tar_quarto(report, "report.qmd") # Make presentation
)
```

### In report.qmd

```

title: My report
format: html

Here is my beautiful data!

```{r}
gt::gt(tar_read(data))
```
```

### Try it

Copy this code to the terminal (not the console!) and try `targets::tar_make()` in the console!

```
cd
mkdir test_targets_quarto
cat > test_targets_quarto/_targets.R <<'EOF'
library(targets)
library(tarchetypes) # Lets you integrate a quarto report/presentation

list(
 tar_target(data, iris),
 tar_target(model, lm(Sepal.Length ~ ., data)),
 tar_quarto(report, "report.qmd") # Make presentation
)
EOF

cat > test_targets_quarto/report.qmd <<'EOF'

title: My project
author: My name
date: today
format:
 typst: default
 docx: default
 html: default
 revealjs:
 output-file: slides.html

Here are some flowers!

gtsummary::tbl_summary(targets::tar_read(data))

And here is a model
```

```
gtsummary::tbl_regression(targets::tar_read(model))
EOF

positron test_targets_quarto
rm -r test_targets_quarto
```

## Manuscripts

- [Quarto Manuscript](#)
- framework for writing and publishing scholarly articles
- Something for your later thesis work?
- Handles references
- Export to Word documents (.docx) etc
  - which is still the most common format for submission to medical/epidemiological journals
  - Still used for collaborative work with non-statisticians etc

## Use references

When writing scientific reports we need to:

- acknowledge previous research
- support claims with evidence
- allow readers to find the original sources

This is done through **citations** and a **reference list**.

Example:

Don't blame me, it was according to H. Wickham, M. Çetinkaya-Rundel, and G. Grolemund [1].

At the end of the document a **bibliography** is automatically generated.

## How Quarto handles references

Quarto uses a **bibliography file**, usually in .bib format.

Example in the document header:

```
bibliography: references.bib
```

Then citations can be written directly in the text:

```
Several studies have examined this relationship @smith2020.
```

Quarto will render something like:

Several studies have examined this relationship (Smith 2020).

The full reference will appear automatically in the bibliography.

### **Online portfolio**

- Looking for a job after you finish the master program?
  - An online portfolio might increase your visibility!
  - Perhaps add your course project to such portfolio?
  - [Demo](#)
- 

### **Bibliography**

- [1] H. Wickham, M. Çetinkaya-Rundel, and G. Grolemund, “R for Data Science (2e).” [Online]. Available: <https://r4ds.hadley.nz/>